

Blood-Burning Moon

Jean Toomer · 1923

First published: Cane, 1923

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Cane_(Toomer)/Blood-Burning_Moon (revision 15075428), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about racial violence in the South?
- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about love and rivalry?
- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about folk song and omen?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Blood-Burning Moon	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*racial violence in the South* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Blood-Burning Moon

Author biography

Jean Toomer was born Nathan Pinchback Toomer in Washington, D.C., on 26 December 1894, the grandson of P. B. S. Pinchback, a Reconstruction-era governor of Louisiana. In 1921 he spent two months as a substitute school principal in Sparta, Georgia, an experience that inspired Cane (1923), a mixture of stories, poems and drama that became a landmark of the Harlem Renaissance. He later resisted being classified by race, became a follower of the mystic G. I. Gurdjieff and later a Quaker, and died on 30 March 1967.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a Georgia mill town in the early 1920s, the story reflects the Jim Crow South, where racial terror, including lynching, enforced segregation. Toomer wrote Cane after working as a substitute school principal in Sparta, Georgia, in 1921.

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in Cane (1923), a mix of stories, poems and drama; it had appeared earlier in the magazine Prairie (1923).

Then: Cane was praised by critics and fellow writers but sold poorly.

Now: Cane is a landmark of the Harlem Renaissance and modernism; this story is one of its most powerful sections.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Louisa, a young Black woman who works in a white family's kitchen, is loved by two men: Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a blood-red moon, the rivalry turns violent.

Main themes

- racial violence and injustice.
- love and possession.
- fate and omen.

Why it matters

The story confronts the history of lynching and its roots in the economics and sexual politics of the post-slavery South.

Spoilers · teacher only

Tom kills Bob in a knife fight; a white mob lynches Tom by burning him alive in the old factory, and Louisa, dazed, sings at her doorstep.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open Blood-Burning Moon: How can a song carry warning or grief?
Prompt: Before we open Blood-Burning Moon: How can a song carry warning or grief?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

modernism; refrain; omen; Harlem Renaissance; lyrical prose.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Jean Toomer was born Nathan Pinchback Toomer in Washington, D.C., on 26 December 1894, the grandson of P. B. S. Pinchback, a Reconstruction-era governor of Louisiana. In 1921 he spent two months as a substitute school principal in Sparta, Georgia, an experience that inspired Cane (1923), a mixture of stories, poems and drama that became a landmark of the Harlem Renaissance. He later resisted being classified by race, became a follower of the mystic G. I. Gurdjieff and later a Quaker, and died on 30 March 1967. The world of the book. Set in a Georgia mill town in the early 1920s, the story reflects the Jim Crow South, where racial terror, including lynching, enforced segregation. Toomer wrote Cane after working as a substitute school principal in Sparta, Georgia, in 1921. Publication and reception. Published in Cane (1923), a mix of stories, poems and drama; it had appeared earlier in the magazine Prairie (1923). Then: Cane was praised by critics and fellow writers but sold poorly. Now: Cane is a landmark of the Harlem Renaissance and modernism; this story is one of its most powerful sections.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"Blood-burning moon. Sinner" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5). The refrain.

> *Blood-burning moon. Sinner (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5)*

Think-aloud: "Blood-burning moon. Sinner" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5). The refrain.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Louisa, a young Black woman who works in a white family's kitchen, is loved by two men: Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a blood-red moon, the rivalry turns violent. Themes to track: racial violence and injustice.: love and possession.: fate and omen.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for Blood-Burning Moon: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does Blood-Burning Moon still matter? The story confronts the history of lynching and its roots in the economics and sexual politics of the post-slavery South.
Anchor question: Why might Blood-Burning Moon still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story confronts the history of lynching and its roots in the economics and sexual politics of the post-slavery South.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why does Toomer repeat the song? Answer: It works as an omen and a chorus, linking the moon to the coming violence.
Exit ticket: Why does Toomer repeat the song?
Answer: It works as an omen and a chorus, linking the moon to the coming violence.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: Blood-Burning Moon.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Jean Toomer" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Jean-Toomer); Poetry Foundation, "Jean Toomer" (https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/jean-toomer); Library of Congress, Jean Toomer and Cane (https://www.loc.gov/); Yale Beinecke Library, Jean Toomer Papers (https://beinecke.library.yale.edu/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Content note: lynching and racial slurs appear in the text, including in the song. Preview and plan carefully. The Prairie magazine prior publication should be checked against a scholarly edition of Cane.

Lesson 2: Blood-Burning Moon

Focus: love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

Content note (graphic lynching, racial slurs, knife killing. strongly recommend teacher preview): Sensitive content: Graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing. Strongly recommend teacher preview. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing. Strongly recommend teacher preview.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old factory. Louisa, unaware, sings to the moon.

Background: Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired.

Significance: A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How can a song or image foreshadow danger? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to racial violence and injustice because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing. Strongly recommend teacher preview.
Prompt: How can a song or image foreshadow danger?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to racial violence and injustice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: canebrake — a thicket of tall cane plants; heralding — announcing that something is coming; jumbled — mixed up in a confused way; trickle — to flow in drops; bordering — coming close (to).
Words: canebrake: a thicket of tall cane plants · heralding: announcing that something is coming · jumbled: mixed up in a confused way · trickle: to flow in drops · bordering: coming close (to)

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired. A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence. Refrain: The song ("Blood-burning moon. Sinner!") recurs, like a chorus. Imagery: Red, fire and blood saturate the story, from the moon to the burning factory. Structure: Three sections: Louisa, Bob, Tom, then convergence. Watch for the moon: omen of violence.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Blood-burning moon. Sinner" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5). The omen. That is refrain at work: The song ("Blood-burning moon. Sinner!") recurs, like a chorus.

> *Blood-burning moon. Sinner* *(Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Blood-burning moon. Sinner" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5). The omen. That is refrain at work: The song ("Blood-burning moon. Sinner!") recurs, like a chorus.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The "white folks' kitchen" shows Louisa's work for Bob's family, the root of the conflict. Ask: How does this line connect to racial violence and injustice? Expected: The mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. (Her divided world.)

> *Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen* *(Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The "white folks' kitchen" shows Louisa's work for Bob's family, the root of the conflict.
Ask: How does this line connect to racial violence and injustice?
Expected answer: The mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. (Her divided world.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for refrain, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Blood-Burning Moon develops the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. When the text says “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55), it shows this directly. The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled.

Task: Annotate the story for refrain, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Blood-Burning Moon develops the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. When the text says “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55), it shows this directly. The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: How can a song or image foreshadow danger? Handle with care: frame discussion around history and Toomer's craft.

Anchor question: How can a song or image foreshadow danger?

Facilitation: Handle with care: frame discussion around history and Toomer's craft.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. (“Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat”, Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. (“Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat”, Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how refrain shapes love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Key takeaway: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Refrain:** The song ("Blood-burning moon. Sinner!") recurs, like a chorus.
- **Imagery:** Red, fire and blood saturate the story, from the moon to the burning factory.
- **Structure:** Three sections: Louisa, Bob, Tom, then convergence.

Themes and how they develop

- **racial violence and injustice:** the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged.

Symbols and motifs

- **the moon:** omen of violence.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5) The omen.
- “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2) Her divided world.
- “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55) The violence.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal.
Evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55)
Reasoning: The song "Blood-burning moon. Sinner!" recurs as the conflict builds, so when "a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat," the reader feels the omen fulfilled.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
canebrake (noun)	a thicket of tall cane plants	*To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

heralding (verb)	announcing that something is coming	*Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
jumbled (verb)	mixed up in a confused way	*But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
trickle (verb)	to flow in drops	*Nails scratches let little lines of blood trickle down and mat into the hair.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bordering (verb)	coming close (to)	*He crashed into the bordering canebrake.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cookery (noun)	the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat	*He passed the house with its huge open hearth which, in the days of slavery, was the plantation cookery.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
embarrassed (verb)	cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious	*Then, with their eyes still upon him, he began to feel embarrassed.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ambling (verb)	walking at a slow, easy pace	*He went towards her, ambling, touched the brim of a marvelously shaped, spotted, felt hat, said he wanted to say something to her, and then found that he didnt know what he had to say, or if he did, that he couldnt say it.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How can a song or image foreshadow danger?
2. Where does imagery appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with racial violence in the South?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What do the women read the full moon as? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: An omen
2. Who are Louisa's two suitors? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Tom Burwell and Bob Stone

3. What building dominates the setting? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: An old pre-war cotton factory
4. How does Bob Stone die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Tom cuts his throat in a fight
5. What does Louisa do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Sings to the moon, unaware
6. Retell the three most important events of "Blood-Burning Moon" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old factory. Louisa, unaware, sings to the moon.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "Blood-Burning Moon"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "Blood-Burning Moon" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new." What does "canebrake" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: canebrake: a thicket of tall cane plants.
10. Reread: "Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening." What does "heralding" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: heralding: announcing that something is coming.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "Blood-Burning Moon" suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.
2. Find one example of imagery in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: "Blood-burning moon. Sinner" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins "Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came.", why might Toomer have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.

5. What causes the main turn in “Blood-Burning Moon”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old…
6. As the opening story, what does “Blood-Burning Moon” set up that the rest of Blood-Burning Moon will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. On structure: Three sections: Louisa, Bob, Tom, then convergence. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How can a song or image foreshadow danger?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does foreshadowing appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with racial violence in the South? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Blood-Burning Moon” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Blood-Burning Moon”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to love and rivalry: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Toomer need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Blood-burning moon. Sinner” (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the imagery in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: “Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks'

kitchen" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. On imagery: Red, fire and blood saturate the story, from the moon to the burning factory. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how "Blood-Burning Moon" treats love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Blood-Burning Moon see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: "Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve racial violence in the South? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: "Blood-burning moon. Sinner" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 5): The omen. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: "Louisa sang as she came over the crest of the hill from the white folks' kitchen" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 2): Her divided world. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Jean Toomer about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Toomer's refrain makes the violence feel fated and communal. Useful evidence: "Blue flash, a steel blade slashed across Bob Stone's throat" (Blood-Burning Moon, paragraph 55): The violence. Theme link: the mob kills Tom, while Bob's actions go unjudged. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Imagery:** look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events

Chapter quiz

1. What do the women read the full moon as?
    A. A blessing
    B. Nothing
    C. A sign of rain
    D. An omen
2. Who are Louisa's two suitors?
    A. Tom Burwell and Bob Stone
    B. Bob and Jim
    C. Tom and Sam
    D. Two brothers
3. What building dominates the setting?
    A. A school
    B. A church
    C. An old pre-war cotton factory
    D. A courthouse
4. How does Bob Stone die?
    A. He falls
    B. Tom cuts his throat in a fight
    C. He drowns
    D. He is shot
5. What does Louisa do at the end?
    A. Sings to the moon, unaware
    B. Flees
    C. Calls for help
    D. Joins the mob
6. In the line “To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.”, what does “canebrake” most nearly mean?
    A. announcing that something is coming
    B. mixed up in a confused way
    C. to flow in drops
    D. a thicket of tall cane plants
7. In the line “Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.”, what does “heralding” most nearly mean?
    A. a thicket of tall cane plants
    B. mixed up in a confused way
    C. to flow in drops
    D. announcing that something is coming

Answer key: 1. D (An omen); 2. A (Tom Burwell and Bob Stone); 3. C (An old pre-war cotton factory); 4. B (Tom cuts his throat in a fight); 5. A (Sings to the moon, unaware); 6. D (a thicket of tall cane plants); 7. D (announcing that something is coming)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Blood-Burning Moon," how does Toomer show love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the imagery you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In Blood-Burning Moon, how does Toomer develop the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the imagery in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Blood-Burning Moon develops the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (where it begins, turns and ends) and its imagery shape the reader's understanding of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Blood-Burning Moon suggests about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's imagery and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Jean Toomer uses imagery in Blood-Burning Moon to complicate the reader's understanding of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Blood-Burning Moon within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Blood-Burning Moon alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence follows or bends those conventions, using the imagery as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Blood-Burning Moon and its treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's imagery and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Blood-Burning Moon as evidence for a larger claim about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence in Blood-Burning Moon. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Blood-Burning Moon as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Blood-Burning Moon.

SAT-style questions

1. *But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “jumbled” most nearly mean?

   A. cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious

   B. walking at a slow, easy pace

   C. the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat

   D. mixed up in a confused way

2. *Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came. Up from the dusk the full moon came. Glowing like a fired pine-knot, it illumined the great door and soft showered the Negro shanties aligned along the single street of factory town. The full moon in the great door was an omen. Negro women improvised songs against its spell.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Blood-Burning Moon”?

   A. The art of the deadpan tall tale

   B. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

   C. Revenge carried out with perfect control

   D. A choice the reader must make

SAT key: 1. D (mixed up in a confused way); 2. B (Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence)

Whole-book test

Blood-Burning Moon: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What do the women read the full moon as?
   A. A blessing
   B. Nothing
   C. A sign of rain
   D. An omen
2. Who are Louisa's two suitors?
   A. Tom Burwell and Bob Stone
   B. Bob and Jim
   C. Tom and Sam
   D. Two brothers
3. What building dominates the setting?
   A. A school
   B. A church
   C. An old pre-war cotton factory
   D. A courthouse
4. How does Bob Stone die?
   A. He falls
   B. Tom cuts his throat in a fight
   C. He drowns
   D. He is shot
5. What does Louisa do at the end?
   A. Sings to the moon, unaware
   B. Flees
   C. Calls for help
   D. Joins the mob
6. In the line “To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.”, what does “canebrake” most nearly mean?
   A. announcing that something is coming
   B. mixed up in a confused way
   C. to flow in drops
   D. a thicket of tall cane plants

7. In the line “Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.”, what does “heralding” most nearly mean?
   A. a thicket of tall cane plants
   B. mixed up in a confused way
   C. to flow in drops
   D. announcing that something is coming
8. As used in the story (“To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.”), what does “canebrake” mean?
   A. a thicket of tall cane plants
   B. coming close (to)
   C. walking at a slow, easy pace
   D. to flow in drops
9. As used in the story (“Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.”), what does “heralding” mean?
   A. the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat
   B. announcing that something is coming
   C. a thicket of tall cane plants
   D. coming close (to)
10. As used in the story (“But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.”), what does “jumbled” mean?
    A. cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious
    B. announcing that something is coming
    C. mixed up in a confused way
    D. the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat
11. As used in the story (“Nails scratches let little lines of blood trickle down and mat into the hair.”), what does “trickle” mean?
    A. walking at a slow, easy pace
    B. mixed up in a confused way
    C. cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious
    D. to flow in drops
12. As used in the story (“He crashed into the bordering canebrake.”), what does “bordering” mean?
    A. coming close (to)
    B. a thicket of tall cane plants
    C. to flow in drops
    D. walking at a slow, easy pace

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how racial violence in the South develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how love and rivalry develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how folk song and omen develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (racial violence in the South, love and rivalry, folk song and omen) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. D (An omen); 2. A (Tom Burwell and Bob Stone); 3. C (An old pre-war cotton factory); 4. B (Tom cuts his throat in a fight); 5. A (Sings to the moon, unaware); 6. D (a thicket of tall cane plants); 7. D (announcing that something is coming); 8. A (a thicket of tall cane plants); 9. B (announcing that something is coming); 10. C (mixed up in a confused way); 11. D (to flow in drops); 12. A (coming close (to))

Essay assignments

Essay: Racial violence in the South

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about racial violence in the South. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops racial violence in the South across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of racial violence in the South. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of racial violence in the South, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of racial violence in the South in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least

four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Love and rivalry

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about love and rivalry. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops love and rivalry across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of love and rivalry. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of love and rivalry, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of love and rivalry in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Folk song and omen

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about folk song and omen. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops folk song and omen across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of folk song and omen. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of folk song and omen, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of folk song and omen in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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